HOW TO PLAY DAGGERHEART

4, 8–9

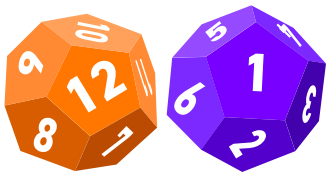
- The GM describes the situation, narrates events, and controls NPCs, adversaries, and obstacles the PCs encounter.
- You roleplay your PC's reaction to the scenario, declaring their action and dialogue.
- If your action depends on fate or fortune, the GM calls for an action roll. To make an action roll, you roll your Duality Dice—two distinct twelve-sided dice (d12s)—representing **Hope** and **Fear**. The dice are rolled, summed, and relevant bonuses called modifiers are added to the result.
- The total is compared to a Difficulty set by the GM. If the total meets or beats the Difficulty, you succeed. If it's lower, you fail.
- The situation also changes based on which Duality Die rolls higher, giving the player helpful **Hope**, or giving adversary **Fear** to the GM.

PLAYER PRINCIPLES

- Be a fan of your character.
- Spotlight your friends.
- Address the characters and the players.
- Build the world together.
- Play to find out what happens.
- Hold on gently.

PLAYER BEST PRACTICES

- Embrace danger.
- Use your resources.
- Tell the story.
- Discover your character.



CLASSES AND DOMAINS

14–15, 24–26

GM PRINCIPLES

142–147

- Begin and end with the fiction.
- Collaborate at all times, especially during conflict.
- Fill the world with life, wonder, and danger.
- Ask questions and incorporate the answers.
- Give every roll impact.
- Play to find out what happens.
- Hold on gently.

GM BEST PRACTICES

- Cultivate a curious table.
- Gain players' trust.
- Keep the story moving forward.
- Cut to the action.
- Help the players use the game.
- Create a meta conversation.
- Tell them what they would know.
- Ground the world in motive.
- Bring the game's mechanics to life.
- Reframe rather than reject.
- Work in moments and montages.

PITFALLS TO AVOID

- Undermining the heroes.
- Always telling the players what to roll.
- Letting scenes drag.
- Overplanning.
- Hoarding Fear.

> *When it comes to Fear, spend fast, spend big, and spend often!*

DICE

A polyhedral die is noted by the number of sides it has—for example, a **d6** is a six-sided die. Multiple dice are called for, too—for example, **2d10** is two ten-sided dice. Each player will need at least **2d12** for **Duality Dice**, and at least one **d20**, **d10**, **d8**, **d6**, and **d4** each. At higher levels—or if you're the GM—you'll need several dice of each size. You can share dice with others. If you can't use dice, any method of generating random numbers works.

OG-DHSRD: OLD GUS' DAGGERHEART SYSTEM REFERENCE DOCUMENT

https://callmepartario.github.io/og-dhsrd

GM screen updated 2026-05-01

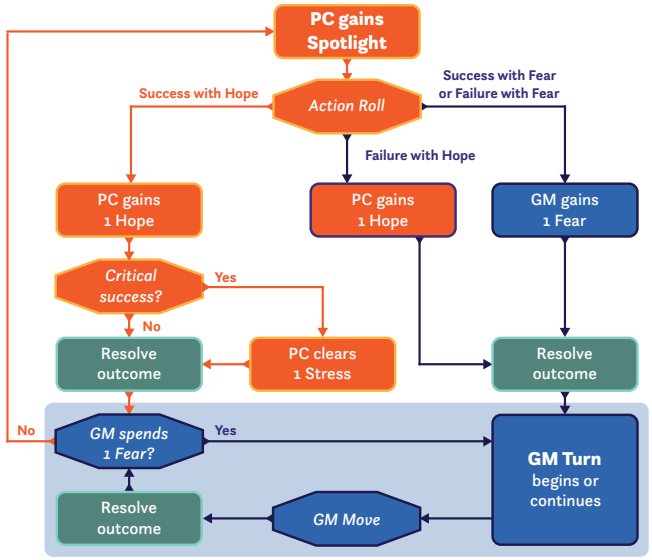
FLOW OF THE GAME

87–90, 193–194

STEP 1: SET THE SCENE

STEP 2: ASK AND ANSWER QUESTIONS

STEP 3: BUILD ON THE FICTION



ACTION ROLLS

17, 90–95, 148–150, 157–160

STEP 1: PICK AN APPROPRIATE TRAIT

Agility	Strength	Finesse	Instinct	Presence	Knowledge
Sprint	Lift	Control	Perceive	Charm	Recall
Leap	Smash	Hide	Sense	Perform	Analyze
Maneuver	Grapple	Tinker	Navigate	Deceive	Comprehend

STEP 2: DETERMINE THE DIFFICULTY

5	10	15	20	25	30
Very Easy	Easy	Average	Hard	Very Hard	Nearly Impossible

STEP 3: APPLY BONUS DICE AND MODIFIERS

STEP 4: ROLL THE DICE

STEP 5: RESOLVE THE OUTCOME

Difficulty	Higher Hope Die	Higher Fear Die
Meets or beats	Success with Hope "Yes, and…"	Success with Fear "Yes, but…"
Less than	Failure with Hope "No, but…"	Failure with Fear "No, and…"

If Duality Dice results are equal, the result is **Critical Success (Crit)**, a special kind of **Success with Hope**. If the GM rolls a natural 20 on the **GM's die** for an adversary, they crit.

SPECIAL ROLLS

97, 99, 148, 161

REACTION ROLLS

Reaction rolls don't generate **Hope** or **Fear**, and don't trigger additional GM moves. Other PCs can't use Help an Ally.

On a crit, ignore any effects. If the GM rolls a natural 20 on the **GM's die** for an adversary, the adversary crits.

GROUP ACTION ROLLS

The party chooses a PC to lead the action and describe how their PC cooperates. The leader makes an action roll, and the other PCs make reaction rolls. Modify the action roll results based on each reaction roll:

- **Success:** +1
- **Failure:** –1

TAG TEAM ROLLS

Once each session, A PC can **spend 3 Hope** to initiate a with another PC. describe how they coordinate actions. Each makes an action roll, and they choose one roll result.

- **Roll with Hope:** The involved PCs gain a Hope.
- **Roll with Fear:** GM gains a Fear for each involved PC.

If the roll is a successful attack, the involved PCs each make a damage roll and total them together. If the attacks deal different damage types, the players choose which type.

ADVANTAGE AND DISADVANTAGE

90, 100, 107, 160

Advantage and disadvantage can result from features, mechanical triggers, or GM discretion.

ADVANTAGE

- **PCs:** Roll a **d6** and add the result to the total.
- **Adversaries:** Roll a second **d20**. Keep the higher result.

DISADVANTAGE

- **PCs:** Roll a **d6** and subtract the result from the total.
- **Adversaries:** Roll a second **d20**. Keep the lower result.

MULTIPLE SOURCES

Each source of advantageous or disadvantage cancels the other out. Disadvantage also cancels other d6 bonus dice—for example, d6 **Rally Dice** and **Slayer Dice**.

HELP AN ALLY

If a PC **spends a Hope** to use the **Help an Ally** move, they roll their own advantage die. After all advantage dice are rolled, keep the highest advantage die's result as the bonus to the roll.

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GM TURNS AND GM MOVES

89, 152–153

During a GM turn, PCs can't make moves, **spend Hope**, **mark Stress**, manage their domain card loadouts, or make rolls unless a specific feature allows it.

SOFTER GM MOVES

- NPC action
- The world reacts
- Reveal truth or danger
- Signal imminent threat
- Dangle a goal
- Backstory rears its head
- Something happens elsewhere
- Ask questions, build on answers

HARDER GM MOVES

- Spotlight an adversary
- A PC marks a Stress
- Change the environment
- Collateral damage
- Consequences of party actions
- Capture something
- Remove an opportunity
- The party is split up

FEAR

91, 153–154, 156

Fear costs are cumulative. The GM might need to spend 1 Fear to make another GM move, and more do one of the following:

- Seize the spotlight
- Make another GM move
- Utilize an Experience
- Activate a Fear Feature
- Improvise a major complication

> *Utilizing an Experience add a bonus to an adversary's **d20** roll, or subtracts it from a roll a PC makes against the adversary.*

STRESS

92

When a character marks their last Stress, they become *Vulnerable* until they clear a Stress.

CONDITIONS

102, 154

HIDDEN

Hidden characters can't be seen. Their location is unknown to their enemies. Rolls against them have disadvantage. If seen due to movement or if they attack, the *Hidden* condition ends.

RESTRAINED

Restrained characters can't move. They can take actions from their current position.

VULNERABLE

Rolls against them have advantage.

CLEARING CONDITIONS

- **PCs:** Succeed a trait roll.
- **Adversaries:** Spotlight them.

ADVERSARY ACTIONS

89, 100, 102, 148, 153, 154, 194

Spotlight an adversary to:

- Move within Close range and make a standard attack
- Move within Close range and use an action adversary feature
- Clear a condition
- Sprint within Far or Very Far range
- Take another action the fiction demands

COUNTDOWNS

162

- **Standard:** Tick down each time a PC makes a relevant action roll.
- **Dynamic:** Tick down based on relevant roll results.
- **Consequence:** Leads to negative effects.
- **Loop:** Reset after triggering. The GM can Increase or decrease starting value by 1.
- **Long-Term:** Tick down after long rests.
- **Progress:** Leads to positive effects.
- **Linked:** If one ticks down to 0, end another without effect.
- **Randomized:** Dice determine starting value.

DYNAMIC COUNTOWNS

Roll Result	Progress	Consequence
Failure with Fear	— (or +1)	−3
Failure with Hope	—	−2
Success with Fear	−1	−1
Success with Hope	−2	—
Crit	−3	— (or +1)

BATTLE GUIDE

197

Battle Points = **3 × the number of PCs + 2**

ENCOUNTER MODIFIERS

Encounter	Modifier
Easier or shorter fight	−1
Includes 2 or more Solos	−2
Add **1d4** (or +2) to adversary damage rolls	−2
Deploy an adversary from a lower tier	+1
No Bruisers, Hordes, Leaders, or Solos	+1
Harder or longer fight	+2

SPEND BATTLE POINTS

Adversary Type	Battle Points
Minions (equal to the number of PCs)	1
Social or Support	1
Horde, Ranged, Skulk, or Standard	2
Leader	3
Bruiser	4
Solo	5

MAPS, RANGE, AND MOVEMENT

103–104

Range	Description	Movement	Feet	Meters
Melee	Touch	—	< 5	< 1.5
Very Close	Fine details	Move + action	5–10	1.5–3
Close	Prominent details	Move + action	10–30	3–9
Far	Few details	Agility Roll	30–100	9–30
Very Far	No details	Agility Roll	100–300	30–90
Out of Range	Can't target	—	> 300	> 90

ATTACK ROLLS

96, 104, 148, 160

An attack roll is an action roll intended to inflict harm.

- **PCs:** The trait used is determined by weapon or Spellcast trait.
- **Adversaries:** Rolls a **d20** and adds the adversary's attack bonus. If the result meets or beats the PC's Evasion, the attack succeeds.

LINE OF SIGHT AND COVER

A ranged attacker must have line of sight to the target unless stated otherwise. If the target is partially obstructed, the attack roll has disadvantage.

MULTIPLE TARGETS

Make one attack roll and compare it to each target's Difficulty or Evasion. Make one damage roll and apply the results to each target the attack succeeds against.

AREA OF EFFECT

Unless stated otherwise, area effects are within Very Close range of a point chosen by the character that creates the effect.

DEATH MOVES

7, 106, 182

- **Blaze of Glory:** The PC takes a GM-approved action that automatically crits. After it resolves, they die.
- **Avoid Death:** The player describes how the PC avoid death and rolls their Hope Die. If the result is equal to or less than PC level, gain a scar and lose a Hope slot. Either way, the PC is temporarily *Unconscious*—they can't move, act, or be targeted by attacks. The condition ends they clear a Hit Point, or after a long rest. If a PC loses their last Hope slot, they must retire.
- **Risk It All:** The player rolls Duality Dice. If the Hope Die is higher, the PC distributes the value of the Hope Die, clearing Hit Points or Stress. If the Fear Die is higher, The PC dies. Equal Hope and Fear Dice: Clear all Hit Points and Stress.

DAMAGE ROLLS

91, 96, 98–99, 107, 110, 113

PROFICIENCY

Proficiency determines the number of damage dice PCs roll with weapons and with features that use Proficiency. Features, spells or other effects can cause Proficiency to exceed 6.

SPELLCAST TRAIT

If a feature deals damage using a PC's Spellcast trait of +0 or lower, no dice are rolled.

ADDITIONAL DAMAGE DICE

Some features add dice to the damage roll—for example, domain cards like **Strategic Approach**.

MODIFIERS AND BONUS DICE

Some features call for dice to be rolled separately, with the result added as a modifier—for example, the Bard's **Rally Dice**.

CRITICAL DAMAGE

If the attack roll was a crit, add the maximum possible result of the damage dice to the result—for example, if the damage dice are **1d8 + 1d6**, add **+14** to the result.

INCOMING DAMAGE

Total damage from a single attack or source, then compare it to the target's damage thresholds.

DAMAGE TYPES

- **Physical (phy):** Unarmed attacks and mundane weapons deal physical damage.
- **Magic (mag):** Spells and magic weapons deal magic damage.
- **Direct Damage:** Direct damage can't be reduced by marking Armor Slots.
- **Resistance:** Resistance reduces incoming damage by half (before other modifiers that reduce incoming damage). If an effect deals both physical and magic damage, the target must be resistant to both.
- **Immunity:** Immune targets don't take damage. If an effect deals both physical and magic damage, the target must be immune to both.

DAMAGE THRESHOLDS, HIT POINTS, AND ARMOR

Minor	≥ Major	≥ Severe
Mark 1 HP	Mark 2 HP	Mark 3 HP

When incoming damage causes a PC to mark **Hit Points**, they can mark one Armor Slot instead of a Hit Point.

> ***Massive Damage (Optional Rule):*** *If a character takes damage equal to twice their Severe threshold, mark 4 Hit Points.*

RULES

7, 94, 96, 102, 104, 107, 153

THE GOLDEN RULE

Make the game your own. Don't let rules interfere with the story, characters, or adventure you want.

RULINGS OVER RULES

When in doubt, the GM makes a ruling aligning with the narrative—make it interesting, logical, and story-based!

ROUNDING UP

Round up to the nearest whole number.

USING FEATURES AFTER A ROLL

Unless specified otherwise, add bonuses or benefits are before rolling. If a feature can affect a roll's outcome, use it after the GM announces if the roll succeeds or fails, but before the outcome is resolved or another roll is made.

SPENDING TO INCREASE EFFECTS

PCs can't spend Hope or mark Stress multiple times on the same feature to increase or repeat effects on a single roll.

REROLLING DICE

Always take the new result.

TARGETING

- **Target:** Anything you choose for to affects.
- **Creature:** Living beings.
- **Allies:** Friendly creatures other than you.

MULTIPLE EFFECTS

Characters can maintain effects from multiple features or domain cards at once. The character in control of the effects decides their resolution order. The GM arbitrates any uncertainty.

STACKING EFFECTS

Effects stack, except advantage and disadvantage, resistance, and conditions.

TEMPORARY AND ONGOING EFFECTS

Some effects don't say when they end, so try:

- When the character in control of the effect chooses.
- When fiction demands it.
- When a PC ends it with an action roll.

> *The GM can spend a Fear to end a temporary effect created by PC features and domain cards.*
>
> *Conditions are different. PCs must succeed on a trait roll. The GM can use a GM move to spotlight an adversary to clear a condition affecting them.*

DOWNTIME

105, 181

Each PC chooses two downtime moves, and can manage domain cards loadout without paying Recall Costs.

SHORT REST

- **PCs:** Lasts about an hour. If interrupted, gain no benefits. After three short rests, the next must be a long rest.
- **GM:** Gain **1d4** Fear.

LONG REST

- **PCs:** Several hours of relaxation or sleep. If interrupted, gain short rest benefits for that downtime move instead.
- **GM:** Gain Fear equal to **1d4 + the number of PCs**, and tick down a long-term countdown.

DOWNTIME MOVES

Move	Short Rest Benefits	Long Rest Benefits
Tend to Wounds	Clear **1d4 + Tier** Hit Points (yours or an ally's).	Clear all Hit Points (yours or an ally's).
Clear Stress	Clear **1d4 + Tier** Stress.	Clear all Stress
Repair Armor	Clear **1d4 + Tier** Armor Slots (yours or an ally's).	Clear all Armor Slots (yours or an ally's).
Prepare	Gain a Hope. If preparing with another PC, each gains 2 Hope.	Gain a Hope. If preparing with another PC, each gains 2 Hope.
Work on a Project	—	Tick Progress Countdown down (or assign an action roll).

EXTENDED DOWNTIME

- Fast-forward the story across an extended period.
- **GM:** Gains **1d6** Fear per PC, and tick down relevant long-term countdowns.

GOLD

104, 165

AVERAGE GOLD COSTS

Goods and Services	Gold	Coins
Meals for a party per night	1 Handful	10
Standard inn room per night	1 Handful	10
Luxury inn room per night	1 Bag	100
Carriage ride	2 Handfuls	20
Mount (horse, mule, etc.)	3 Bags	300
Specialized tools	3 Handfuls	30
Fine clothing	3 Handfuls	30
Luxury clothing	1 Bag	100
Tier 1 weapon or armor	1–5 Handfuls	10–50
Tier 2 weapon or armor	1–2 Bags	100–200
Tier 3 weapon or armor	5–10 Bags	500–1000
Tier 4 weapon or armor	1–2 Chests	1000–2000

LOOT AND CONSUMABLES

129–133

- **Common:** 1d12 or 2d12
- **Uncommon:** 2d12 or 3d12
- **Rare:** 3d12 or 4d12
- **Legendary:** 4d12 or 5d12

> *Try modifying loot rolls—**3d20** has a more even distribution than **5d12**. Adding a modifier to a loot roll also changes things—for example, **1d10 + 20** means the results will be evenly spread between **21–30**.*

Roll	Loot	Consumable
1	Premium Bedroll	Stride Potion
2	Piper Whistle	Bolster Potion
3	Charging	Control Potion
4	Alistair's Torch	Attune Potion
5	Speaking Orbs	Charm Potion
6	Manacles	Enlighten Potion
7	Arcane Cloak	Minor Health Potion
8	Woven Net	Minor Stamina Potion
9	Fire Jar	Grindletooth Venom
10	Suspended Rod	Varik Leaves
11	Glamour Stone	Vial of Moondrip
12	Empty Chest	Unstable Arcane Shard
13	Companion Case	Potion of Stability
14	Piercing Arrows	Improved Grindletooth Venom
15	Valorstone	Morphing Clay
16	Skeleton Key	Vial of Darksmoke
17	Arcane Prism	Jumping Root
18	Minor Stamina Potion Recipe	Snap Powder
19	Minor Health Potion Recipe	Health Potion
20	Homing Compasses	Stamina Potion
21	Corrector Sprite	Armor Sticher
22	Gecko Gloves	Gill Salve
23	Lorekeeper	Replication Parchment
24	Vial of Darksmoke Recipe	Improved Arcane Shard
25	Bloodstone	Major Stride Potion
26	Greatstone	Major Bolster Potion
27	Glider	Major Control Potion
28	Ring of Silence	Major Attune Potion
29	Calming Pendant	Major Charm Potion
30	Dual Flask	Major Enlighten Potion
31	Bag of Ficklesand	Blood of the Yorgi
32	Ring of Resistance	Homet's Secret Potion
33	Phoenix Feather	Redthorn Saliva
34	Box of Many Goods	Channelstone
35	Airblade Charm	Mythic Dust
36	Portal Seed	Acidpaste
37	Paragon's Chain	Hopehold Flare
38	Elusive Amulet	Major Arcane Shard
39	Hopekeeper Locket	Featherbone
40	Infinite Bag	Circle of the Void
41	Stride Relic	Sun Tree Sap
42	Bolster Relic	Dripfang Poison
43	Control Relic	Major Health Potion
44	Attune Relic	Major Stamina Potion
45	Charm Relic	Ogre Musk
46	Enlighten Relic	Wingsprout
47	Honing Relic	Jar of Lost Voices
48	Flickerfly Pendant	Dragonbloom Tea
49	Lakestrider Boots	Bridge Seed
50	Clay Companion	Sleeping Sap
51	Mythic Dust Recipe	Feast of Xuria
52	Shard of Memory	Bonding Honey
53	Gem of Alacrity	Shrinking Potion
54	Gem of Might	Growing Potion
55	Gem of Precision	Knowledge Stone
56	Gem of Insight	Sweet Moss
57	Gem of Audacity	Blinding Orb
58	Gem of Sagacity	Death Tea
59	Ring of Unbreakable Resolve	Mirror of Marigold
60	Belt of Unity	Stardrop

GAINING LEVELS

26, 109–111

STEP 1: CHECK FOR TIER ACHIEVEMENTS

STEP 2: PURCHASE ADVANCEMENTS

STEP 3: INCREASE DAMAGE THRESHOLDS BY 1

STEP 4: CHOOSE A DOMAIN CARD

> *You can't choose a domain card with a level greater than yours—or half your level if you gained access to the card's domain deck by multiclassing.*

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DAGGERHEART COMPATIBLE

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